



India overtakes the US

India has overtaken the US to officially become the 2nd largest smartphone market after China. <https://dgit.in/feb20-35>



Moto with a stylus

A leak brought out by Evan Blass (@evleaks) suggests that Motorola is developing a phone with a stylus. <https://dgit.in/feb20-36>

Word of warning, the machines may not be *cough* noob-friendly *cough* but the HTB community focuses more on learning. The HTB forum[<https://forum.hackthebox.eu/>] and their discord server[<https://discord.gg/hackthebox>] is a great place to start whenever you feel you have hit a roadblock in your pentesting experience. A rank system is also present which consists of the following promotion levels:

Noob->Script Kiddie->Hacker->Pro Hacker->Elite Hacker->Guru->Omniscient

The ranks are determined by the overall percent completion, inclusive of both labs and challenges. No demotion system is there, hence once you achieve a rank, you'll have that regardless of your activity status. But as soon as a machine retires, the points are deducted and the overall completion decreases. A new machine is introduced and an old one is retired each week, so you need to keep up your pace if you want to rank up! The maximum rank we have achieved is Elite Hacker (yes, we are flexing).

Alongside the labs we discussed above, several challenges are also provided making HackTheBox, a hybrid of labs and challenges based platform, a leader. Numerous categories are present like steganography, cryptography, binary exploitation, etc, each having a number of challenges. Again, these challenges are created by the members and approved by the staff. After a period of time, each box and challenge is "retired", that is, it is taken off the active listing and only after retirement the write-ups and solutions are allowed to be posted online. A paid VIP mode is available, in which retired boxes and challenges are available to exploit, but the free mode is more than sufficient to get the expertise.

Recently, HackTheBox released an official (ISC)2 CPE Submitter, meaning users can earn CPE credits as they progress through machines and challenges which are considered an industry standard about the experience one has in a specific field. Alas, this feature is only available to VIP users. Here are some platform specific guidelines regarding good conduct that you should follow to

keep the community and the platform enjoyable for everyone:

- Since you are not alone while working on a box, it's suitable to first properly research your methodology so as to not to brick the online machine environment.
- Always remove your traces and any material you might have used to further your progress so as to not spoil the tasks for others. This includes custom scripts, uncovered passwords, retrieved flags, etc.
- Don't remove the user and root flags from their predetermined directories.

Below are some resources which are specific to HackTheBox. They are mostly walkthroughs and write-ups of



past boxes and we can't stress enough how crucial are these to get the correct mindset and the approach required to successfully smash through the boxes:

- "IppSec" channel on YouTube [<https://dgit.in/IppSec>]
- Ahmed Hesham's blog [<https://dgit.in/AHblog>]

2. VulnHub

[<https://www.vulnhub.com/>]

True to their motto "Vulnerable by Design", VulnHub is a platform that provides user-created machines with loopholes and exploitable vulnerabilities deliberately present in them. VulnHub is different from HackTheBox since each vulnerable machine needs to be downloaded and imported to a virtualization software. If you are unfamiliar with the term "virtualization", it means that different operating systems and applications can be installed on top of your current system, without getting your hands dirty with your physical system. So, if you have all the required tools, you don't need an internet connection to practice your hacking skills! No hassle of config file downloads and no VPN setups.

As virtualization is involved, you need to make sure it's enabled in your system. Usually, virtualization is enabled by default and if not, you can always tinker with your BIOS settings to do that. You must have heard of VirtualBox and VMware (Player or Workstation), them being the big guns when it comes to virtualization at personal and consumer level. While VirtualBox is an open-source initiative by Oracle, VMware provides paid software but their VMWare Player is available for free if used for non-commercial purposes. Most of the machines are compatible with both of these software, but some are crafted with a specific software in mind. If you are comfortable with either

VirtualBox or VMWare, a number of methods are available to import/convert machines from one format to another. Most popular formats that machines are available in are as follows:

- Open Virtualization Format (.ova, .ovf): The machine is supplied as a whole package and as a result, file sizes can reach up to 4 gigs. These are supported by both VirtualBox and VMware software. No extra configurations are needed, just import, launch and get hackin'-crackin'.
- Virtual Machine Disk (.vmdk): The virtual hard drives that are attached to the virtual machines. The extension was developed by VMWare and VMware Player supports it natively. Usually a '.vbox' file is supplied with all the configuration already specified and all you have to do is run this with the software, but this is for VirtualBox. But as we said, any appliance can be exported as a ".ova" file from within the software and used with other virtualization software.

Unlike HackTheBox, there are no individual challenges belonging to particular categories that are present